

PITCH — G1A.DE — VERDICT

PROPOSED — PENDING ADJUDICATION — both benches recommend **NO POSITION, NO ORDER, NO STARTER**: the company does not contain the idea we wanted to buy, and what it does contain is priced.

What we believe

We went looking for a way to own the *manufacturing layer* of the non-alcoholic beer boom — the idea being that whichever NA brand wins, somebody has to sell the equipment that takes the alcohol out, and that supplier gets paid on every launch. GEA Group (Frankfurt: G1A) sells exactly that machine: **AromaPlus**, a membrane unit that strips alcohol out of finished beer, sold since 2016 ([product page](#)).

After both benches worked it, here is what we actually believe:

1. **The NA beer trend is real.** No-alcohol volumes grew ~8% in 2025 while beer overall shrank 0.7%. That part of the story holds.
2. **GEA is a good business.** H1 2026: orders €2,949m (+8.3%), revenue €2,716m (+5.7%), margin 16.8%, guidance *raised* in July to 6–8% organic growth and 17.0–17.4% margins with return on capital of 36–40% ([company release](#)).
3. **But GEA is not a way to own the NA beer trend.** The alcohol-removal business is roughly **1% of GEA's revenue** — probably less. Buying the stock to express this idea means buying 99% of something else and calling it the thing you wanted.
4. **We do not have a view on that 99%.** The dairy-and-food capital-equipment cycle that actually drives this company has never been put through our process. It might be a fine investment. We haven't done the work, and we should not inherit a position from the wreckage of a different argument.

So the belief is: **the idea was sound, the vehicle is wrong, and we should say so plainly rather than buy a small piece of the right story wrapped in a large piece of an unexamined one.**

What the market believes

The market believes GEA is a well-run European process-equipment company executing ahead of plan, and it prices it accordingly: **€64.10 per share, about €10.4bn of market value on 162.8m shares**, roughly 20× this year's expected earnings (€3.15–3.22 per share consensus).

Critically, the market believes **nothing in particular about GEA and non-alcoholic beer** — because GEA itself has never put a number on that business. Analysts model dairy, food, pharma and farm equipment. Nobody is modelling a beer-dealcoholization line, up or down. There is no consensus for us to disagree with.

Where analysts land: one service shows an average price target of **€64.06** (16 analysts) — four cents below the current price. Another shows **€69.79** (17 analysts) — about 9% above. That spread is itself informative: it says the sell side thinks this is a fairly-valued good company, and they are arguing about a single-digit percentage, not about a hidden business line.

Why we might have edge

Honestly stated, and then honestly deflated:

- **The real edge here was an information edge about the science, and it worked — it just pointed the other way.** Our science review established that alcohol removal is not proprietary GEA chemistry. The foundational membrane patents belong to **Dow Deutschland, filed 1990–92, long expired** ([WO1992008783A1](#)). Anyone can build this. That is a genuine finding most equity research would not have produced — it just kills the thesis instead of supporting it.
- **We identified that the major brewers all chose someone else.** Heineken 0.0 uses vacuum distillation. Guinness 0.0 uses cold filtration in a purpose-built 500,000-hectolitre facility ([Diageo](#)). Asahi ZERO runs on Alfa Laval stripping modules. **Three for three of the visible global 0.0 programmes bought a non-GEA route.** Every GEA reference customer we could find is a small or mid-size European independent (Andechs, Adnams, Schönbuch, Laitilan, Farny, Kaiserdom).
- **We found the technology that skips the machine entirely.** Kronen/Steinecker with Novonesis use a yeast that never produces alcohol in the first place — so there is nothing to remove, and no removal equipment is bought. And the only live, granted, in-force patent we could find anywhere in this value chain sits at that **ingredient layer**, not the equipment layer: **Chr. Hansen/Novonesis US11162059B2** ([link](#)).

That last point is the most valuable thing this court produced. If the thesis is “the chemistry layer gets paid on every launch,” **we courted the wrong company entirely** — the patented layer is the yeast supplier, and we never looked at it. That is a real, actionable finding, and it is a recommendation to open a new file, not to buy this one.

Why it might be priced in

It isn’t “priced in” so much as **out of scope**. The market isn’t paying for NA beer exposure at GEA because there is no meaningful NA beer exposure at GEA. There is no premium to fade and no discount to collect.

And the rest of the company is priced for its current good performance: the stock is 5.9% off its 52-week high, up ~19.9% from its 52-week low, up ~3.7% year to date, with guidance just raised. At ~20x earnings on peak-cycle margins, you pay full freight. Nothing about the tape suggests a dislocation, a forced seller, or a neglected asset.

What could go wrong

This is the pre-mortem for the position **as if we took it anyway** — because the realistic risk is not that our analysis is wrong, it is that a good company at a fair price quietly gets bought under the banner of an argument that has already failed.

Failure narrative 1 — Perimeter drift (the most likely one). We don't buy the NA thesis; we buy "GEA, quality industrial compounder" at €64 because it's right there and it looks good, and we book it against the beer file. Twelve months later the P&L is driven entirely by European dairy and food plant capex — a variable nobody on this desk has ever forecast, tested, or graded. We would be long an unexamined cycle with a paper trail that says we studied beer. *Tripwire (monitorable)*: at any review, if the largest single driver of the position's return is not the mechanism named in the deck, the position is mis-filed and gets closed or re-courted.

Failure narrative 2 — Cosmetic confirmation. On 9 November GEA publishes its first quarterly report under the new four-division structure. Suppose a "beverage" revenue line appears at €110m+. We declare the thesis vindicated and buy. But GEA's own definition of "Beverage" spans **beer, soft drinks, coffee, juice, wine and spirits** — and management has said on its own earnings calls that alcoholic beer is "only a small portion" of beverage revenue. A big beverage number could be entirely Coca-Cola bottling and orange juice. *Tripwire (monitorable)*: the disclosure only counts if it names **beer** or **dealcoholization** specifically. A "Beverage" aggregate does not clear the gate, at any size.

Failure narrative 3 — NO MONITORABLE TRIPWIRE EXISTS. GEA's revenue is decided inside the capital-expenditure committees of privately-held and multinational food, dairy and beverage companies. Those decisions are made on no published schedule, disclosed nowhere, and reach us only as a backward-looking order-intake number one quarter later. A synchronised customer capex freeze — the kind that follows a credit event or an input-cost shock in food processing — would show up in the stock before it shows up in anything we can read. **Unknown-unknown class: unobservable counterparty capital budgets.** The proof that we are blind here is in this court's own record: **28 alternative-data detectors were consulted across both benches and exactly zero fired.** Not "returned negative" — *uncheckable*. No consumer app, no consumer product, no US customs trail (EU-built equipment sold into the EU), no federal contracts, no disclosed >10% customer, no satellite-observable assets. This company is invisible to our entire sensing apparatus. We would be flying on quarterly press releases like everyone else, with no early-warning capability whatsoever.

The reflexive and structural leg. Our own size is a non-issue: a 0.5% starter against ~\$3.4m of deployable capital is roughly **\$17,000**, against an estimated €23–32m of daily trading in a €10.4bn MDAX name — call it 0.05–0.07% of a day's volume. (*Flagged: actual Xetra average daily volume was never pulled — that range is a base-rate estimate for a name this size, and it is item 6 in the unverified list.*) We cannot move this stock and we are not front-running our own flow. The reflexive risk here is **doctrinal, not market-impact**: our own "a clean court with no named objection defaults to a small starter" rule would, applied mechanically, put us into this stock. Both benches explicitly refused that, and they are right — that rule exists for names where the risks were

examined and found to be fairly paid, not for names where **the company turned out not to contain the idea**. A second structural note: this is a euro-denominated stock in a dollar-reporting book, so an unhedged position adds currency variance and no edge.

If this position loses money, the most likely reason will be that we ended up owning an unexamined European food-and-dairy capital-equipment cycle at roughly 20× peak-margin earnings, while telling ourselves we owned the non-alcoholic beer chemistry layer — and that cycle turned inside customer capital budgets we have no ability to observe.

What we checked ourselves

Claim	How checked	Found	Confirmed?
The total market for alcohol-removal equipment can reach 2% of GEA revenue	Rebuilt from primaries: 1.896bn hl world beer × ~2% NA share × 8% growth = +3.0m hl/yr of new NA volume; divided by AromaPlus unit throughput (18k–365k hl/yr); priced at ~€1.5m per new unit	Even at 50% utilisation and a 100% GEA monopoly on all world NA equipment, ceiling = ~€495m = 9.0% of group revenue . At GEA's demonstrated share (6 small/mid references over a decade, 0-for-3 at the visible majors): €50–99m = 0.9–1.8%	YES — and it survives a 3× error in the price-per-unit assumption
Same claim, checked a second, independent way	Management's own words on the Q1/Q2 2026 earnings calls	"Alcoholic beer and alcoholic beverages make up only a small portion of GEA's beverage revenue, which also includes carbonated drinks and juices." Beverage is 12% of sales ≈ €659m ; beer is a small slice of that; alcohol-removal is a slice of the slice	YES — this is stronger evidence than our own arithmetic and does not depend on any of our assumptions
BENCH ERROR — "GEA never mentions non-alcoholic beer anywhere, which proves it's immaterial"	Red bench graded a keyword absence in the Mission 30 strategy release as a fatal finding; blue bench read the actual earnings calls	REFUTED . GEA management does discuss it — "alcoholic beer structurally softer," "better momentum in non-alcoholic beer." The correct, weaker claim is that GEA never sizes it — which is just the materiality finding again, not a second one	NO — overturned . We graded a press-release word search as evidence. That was sloppy
BENCH ERROR — "The alcohol-removal business sits in GEA's worst-margin division (11.4%)"	Red inferred this from a slide's product mapping; blue checked the Q2 call transcript	REFUTED . GEA states beverage contributed to order growth in Pure Flow Processing — the 26.7%-margin division — and the division red called "worst" grew order intake +40% organic . The negative	NO — overturned . Red flagged it as weak and did not rest on it; correct call, and it still shouldn't have been written as a finding

Claim	How checked	Found	Confirmed?
		figure circulating in secondary coverage belongs to a different division entirely	
BENCH ERROR — “The analyst price target equals the share price, so there’s no upside”	Red quoted €64.06 vs €64.10 — but red’s own text also carried €69.79 (+8.9%) from a second service, waved away	PARTIALLY WRONG. Cherry-picked one of two available numbers. The defensible version is different and weaker: <i>we produced no independent fair value and no mechanism for a price gap</i> , because the only mechanism we proposed was NA beer, and NA beer is ~1% of revenue	NO as stated; YES as corrected
BENCH ERROR — forward P/E of 19.2x	Recomputed: €64.10 ÷ €3.15–3.22 consensus EPS = 19.9–20.3x . 19.2x implies €3.34 of earnings, above the range quoted in the same paragraph	Small internal inconsistency; the stock is slightly <i>more</i> expensive than we said	NO — arithmetic slip. Immaterial to the verdict, but it went unnoticed by both benches
BENCH ERROR — both benches declared a probability/price table “not applicable”	Both said GEA is a cash-generative industrial, not a pre-revenue project, so the requirement doesn’t attach	Wrong trigger applied. The requirement attaches when there is a time-gated or private unverified item — and there are several (the 9 Nov segment disclosure; the private install count). Table built below	NO — corrected in this deck
The major brewers chose non-GEA technology	Company primaries for each	Heineken 0.0 = vacuum distillation; Guinness 0.0 = cold filtration; Asahi ZERO = Alfa Laval stripping (2024). 3 for 3	YES , but softened: GEA also sells the <i>biological</i> route hardware, so a customer switching methods may still buy from GEA. Red omitted that; blue caught it
There are only three competing routes	Blue ran further patent searches	Five. Add zeolite adsorption (Clariant/Soralco, EP3807393A1) and Flavologic ES3042370T3. More routes, none GEA’s	YES — worse than we thought
GEA holds no patents on alcohol removal	Five automated patent-office runs	NOT A RESULT. All five failed with an HTTP 503 transport error. A search that didn’t run is not a search that found nothing. Blue partially reopened it via a proxy but could not	NO — this remains open. See unverified item 3

Claim	How checked	Found	Confirmed?
		get the assignee filter to bind reliably	
Alcohol removal is a shrinking-pie retrofit that cannibalises GEA's own conventional brewhouse sales	Red's original argument, checked against our own evidence	Weakened. Guinness built a dedicated new 500,000 hl facility — that is added capacity, not converted. The mechanism is real but unquantified and our flagship counterexample contradicts it	Downgraded to a sizing flag
Used equipment caps new-machine pricing	One broker listing: a used GEA reverse-osmosis dealcoholization system at \$450k	One listing of unknown age and specification is not a liquid market, and a used skid is not substitutable for a warranted, serviced new line	Downgraded to a flag; not relied upon
Next reporting date 2026-11-09	Data feed said “unconfirmed”; both benches checked GEA's investor calendar	Confirmed by primary. ~46 trading days away — not close enough to require a pre-print reconstruction	YES
Share count and market value tie out	162.8m shares × €64.10 = €10.43bn vs €10.44bn quoted	Clean. No dilution, no follow-on, no share-count artifact	YES
Our alternative-data sensors say something	28 detectors run across both benches	Zero fired. All either uncheckable (no consumer product, no app, no US customs trail, no federal contracts) or not-fired. Also: the two benches were dispatched different detector lists — a routing bug worth fixing	YES — and this is itself a finding (see failure narrative 3)

PROPOSED ENTRY BANDS

No entry. No order. No starter position. Size: 0.0% of book.

Price does not fix this. The objection is not “good company, too expensive” — it is “this company does not contain the thing we wanted to buy.” A cheaper price would not put a beer-dealcoholization business inside GEA. So there is no entry level for the NA thesis at any price, and quoting one would be dishonest.

Reopen conditions instead — what would have to be true, with dates and levels:

A. Reopens the NA thesis (evidence-gated, not price-gated): 1. 2026-11-09 — Q3 2026 quarterly statement, the first report under the new four-division structure. This is the first venue where a segment note could disclose a brewing or dealcoholization revenue line.
Threshold: ≥€110m (2% of FY2025 revenue of €5,495m), **and the line must name beer or**

dealcoholization specifically — a “Beverage” aggregate does not count, because that bucket contains soft drinks, coffee and juice by GEA’s own definition. 2. A **brewer-side** press release naming AromaPlus at a top-20 global brewer, or a GEA-published installed-unit count **above 100 units**. 3. An industry survey (BarthHaas, VLB, Brewers of Europe) splitting NA beer volume by production method showing physical alcohol removal **above 70% share and rising** against the biological route. 4. An independent cost comparison putting AromaPlus PRO **below €2.8–3.8 per hectolitre** at the 0.05% alcohol level — the number Alfa Laval publicly claims for its own equipment.

None of items 2–4 is dated or scheduled. Only item 1 has a calendar date.

B. Triggers a NEW court on a DIFFERENT thesis (price-gated): - Below €54.00 — approximately 17× the midpoint of the 2026 consensus earnings range (€3.18), and essentially the 52-week low of €53.45. At that level the *industrial compounder* case (order intake +40% organic in Nutrition Plant Engineering, return on capital 36–40%, beverage landing in the 26.7%-margin division) deserves its own diligence file. **To be explicit: that is a new thesis requiring a full court from scratch — it is not this one reopening, and it must not inherit this deck’s work.**

C. Recommended separate work — the finding worth acting on: - Open a science-stage file on **Novonesis (Copenhagen: NSIS-B.CO)** before this thesis is retired. If the belief is “the chemistry layer gets paid on every NA beer launch,” Novonesis holds the only live granted patent we found in the entire chain (US11162059B2), sells into *both* the physical and the biological routes, and was never on our candidate list.

Catalyst dates: - **2026-10-05** — pre-close analyst call (bench-asserted from the investor calendar; not independently re-confirmed) - **2026-10-06 to 2026-11-09** — company quiet period - **2026-11-09** — Q3 2026 quarterly statement, new segment structure (confirmed against GEA’s investor calendar by both benches)

ARMED SENSORS

(armed provisionally with this deck; session adjudication ratifies)

- price alert: fires below 53.45 (deck-provisional: 52-week low breached - confirms the compounder-court trigger and flags a regime change in a name that)
- dated pack G1A.DE|2026-10-05: G1A.DE: Pre-close analyst call ahead of Q3; quiet period runs 2026-10-06 to 2026-11-09 (date confirmed=False)
- dated pack G1A.DE|2026-11-09: G1A.DE: Q3 2026 quarterly statement - first report under the new four-division structure; the >=EUR 110m beer/dealcoholization disclosure ga

What remains unverified

1. **GEA’s actual brewing / alcohol-removal revenue.** Not drainable now — the company has never disclosed it, and the first possible venue is the 9 Nov segment note. *Estimate: €25–95m, i.e. 0.5–1.7% of group revenue*, derived from beverage at €659m (12% of sales),

management's "small portion of beverage revenue" for all alcoholic beer, and alcohol-removal equipment being a sub-slice of that. Probability a line $\geq$ €110m is disclosed on 9 Nov: **0.07**.

2. **How many AromaPlus units GEA has actually sold since 2016.** Not drainable now — the reference list is under customer NDA. *Estimate: 15–40 cumulative units*, from 6 publicly named references over ten years and a typical roughly-1-in-4 ratio of published to unpublished industrial references. Probability the true count exceeds 100: **0.10**.
3. **Whether GEA holds any live patent on alcohol removal. Drainable now** — Espacenet or DPMA assignee query under classification C12H3/00. Google Patents returns 503 to direct fetch but resolves through the r.jina.ai proxy. This is the single cheapest open item and it should be closed this week regardless of the verdict.
4. **What share of NA beer volume is made by physically removing alcohol versus never making it.** Not drainable now — no vendor or trade body publishes the split. *Estimate: 55–75% physical removal today and falling*, inferred from the installed base being mostly conventional breweries retrofitting, against a biological route that is newer but requires no capital equipment. Probability it is above 70% and rising: **0.15**.
5. **Real operating cost per hectolitre, AromaPlus PRO versus stripping, at the 0.0% label.** Not drainable now — neither vendor has published an independent head-to-head, and both sides' numbers are self-reported. *Estimate: GEA €3.5–6.0/hl at 0.05% alcohol* versus Alfa Laval's asserted €2.8–3.8/hl, reflecting that reverse osmosis needs large volumes of diafiltration water to reach that level. Probability GEA is genuinely cheaper: **0.25**.
6. **G1A.DE trading liquidity and its Eurex option chain. Drainable now** via IBKR — average daily volume, real bid/ask on specific strikes, and chain-level implied volatility. Nobody pulled it, which is why the volatility section below is partly estimated rather than measured. *Working estimate meanwhile: €23–32m traded per day*, base-rated off a €10.4bn MDAX constituent.
7. **Which division the alcohol-removal equipment actually reports into.** Our two benches disagreed: the company slide deck implies the 11.4%-margin engineering division; the earnings call implies beverage contributed in the 26.7%-margin division. Not fully drainable until the 9 Nov segment note. *Estimate: a split — roughly 60% of beverage-related revenue in Pure Flow Processing (separators, valves, filtration), 40% in Nutrition Plant Engineering (brewhouse skids)*. Probability the dealcoholization skid specifically sits in the lower-margin engineering division: **0.70**.

PRIZE TABLE + VOL READ

Both benches declared this section not applicable on the grounds that GEA is a profitable industrial rather than a pre-revenue project. That is the wrong test — the section is required because **items 1, 2, 4, 5 and 7 above are genuinely time-gated or private**. Built here, over the horizon from today to the December Eurex expiry (2026-12-18, 106 days, $T = 0.29$ years).

Anchor: the current price, €64.10. Analyst targets bracket it at €64.06 and €69.79. Under our anchoring discipline, any scenario-weighted value more than $\pm 5\%$ from the anchor requires a named mechanism.

#	Scenario	Probability	Price	Contribution
1	Q3 discloses a beer/dealcoholization line $\geq$ €110m — our thesis is vindicated	0.07	€66.00	€4.62
2	Q3 in line, guidance held	0.55	€65.00	€35.75
3	Q3 beat, guidance raised again (H1 momentum continues)	0.20	€70.00	€14.00
4	Q3 miss, order intake decelerates, guidance trimmed	0.15	€56.00	€8.40
5	Broad industrial de-rate to ~16× earnings	0.03	€51.00	€1.53
	Expected value	1.00		€64.30

Expected value €64.30 versus a €64.10 price is +0.3% — inside the $\pm 5\%$ band, so no mechanism is owed and none is claimed. Our own honest scenario table reproduces the market price. That is the whole trade in one number.

Note the most damning row: **scenario 1, the one where we are right, is worth about +3%.** A disclosure confirming a €110m business inside a €5,495m company is a research vindication, not a stock move. Even winning doesn't pay.

Dispersion: the probability-weighted standard deviation of the table is $\sigma = \text{€}4.76$, or **7.4% of spot over 106 days**, which annualises to about **13.8%**. The table is mildly two-sided around the 9 November print (a €70 beat branch against a €56 miss branch), but the fork is roughly $\pm 9\%$ and not binary — this is not an event with a bimodal payoff.

Expression math — priced off the table itself: - A December €70 call: $C = \sum p_i \times \max(S_i - 70, 0) = \text{€}0.00$. Our table assigns zero value above €70. - A December €65 call: $(0.07 \times \text{€}1.00) + (0.20 \times \text{€}5.00) = \text{€}1.07$, or 1.7% of spot. - What the chain would likely charge for that €65 call at a typical European industrial volatility of ~25%: roughly **€3.40** ($0.4 \times S \times \sigma \times \sqrt{T}$). **About three times what our own table says it is worth.**

Stated plainly: we do not have real chain quotes. No bench pulled the Eurex chain, so the €3.40 is a model estimate at an assumed volatility, not a midpoint. Under our own rule — never substitute an aggregate volatility feed for chain-level quotes, because they diverge badly — that comparison is **provisional and the pull is owed** (unverified item 6). But the direction is not close: our table implies ~13.8% annualised volatility against a market that almost certainly charges 22–30% for a name like this, so implied volatility looks **rich versus our own scenario dispersion**, not cheap.

Instrument recommendation, as the output of the arithmetic: NONE. - **Buying calls:** rejected. Our table values them at roughly a third of their likely cost. Cheap volatility would be the case for expressing a gated thesis in calls; this is the opposite. - **Selling premium:** rich implied volatility would ordinarily route to the premium-selling gates, and a cash-secured put would collect it. **Barred.** The governing test for selling a put is whether we would willingly own the stock at the strike — and we have just spent an entire court concluding we do not want to own this stock at any price for this reason. Selling puts on a name we rejected is a back door into the position we refused. It also fails on wrapper grounds: premium selling in a taxable account is restricted to a short list of templates, none of which fits a name with no position and no thesis. - **Covered calls:** impossible; we own no shares. - **Stock:** rejected on the perimeter grounds above.

Tax overlay: moot at zero size, but recorded for completeness. A December 2026 expiry would land any loss inside the current tax year, which is the correct side of the line during a harvest year — a March or June 2027 expiry would push the loss into next year and would be excluded. This does not rescue anything: no expression clears the prior gates.

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(Membranes 13(3):329 quantifies the flux collapse); competitor FAQ gives the
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ADJUDICATION STAMP — 2026-09-04 (FABLE) — NA-CHEMISTRY FAMILY RULING

THESIS REJECTED on all five chemistry-layer expressions; with the brewer courts this closes the NA-substitution FAMILY: seven expressions, three layers, seven deaths on the same denominator. Three independent instruments converge: the global purchased-chemistry pool for NA repair is \$11–55M (IFF benches); a full Kerry monopoly on it re-rates the equity 1.5–4.7% (the impossible case); GEA's monopoly-everything bull is 9% of group at its worst-margin division vs 0.9–1.8% demonstrated. Every FLAT is earned by named novel kills. Blue audits corrected three red financial cases — Givaudan is FAIR not expensive (RP_TAINTED was misapplied), Symrise's deceleration was a period-selection artifact, IFF looks better as a business post-audit — so four spin-off theses route to their own courts rather than inheriting this one: GIVN quality/TINA, SY1 compounder (alert €72), KRZ compounder (ROE gate), G1A industrial compounder (NPE +40% organic). Family reopens on: Athletic Brewing S-1, 2587.T Oceania disclosure (11/11 pack), G1A's 11/09 segment note ($\geq$ €110M brewing line — the one dated trigger), or any primary putting NA ingredient value $>$ \$8–24/hL. The yeast-supplier IP finding is the one new scout lead. SCIENCE stage maiden run: validated — all five briefs pre-empted the traps the brewer courts hit mid-argument. 13 KG detectors accepted, incl. the monopoly-capture/per-unit-breakeven prize-test pair (“price the roof before arguing the ladder”). Full ruling: [desk/data/court_artifacts/NA_CHEMISTRY_ADJUDICATION_202609040700.md](#).